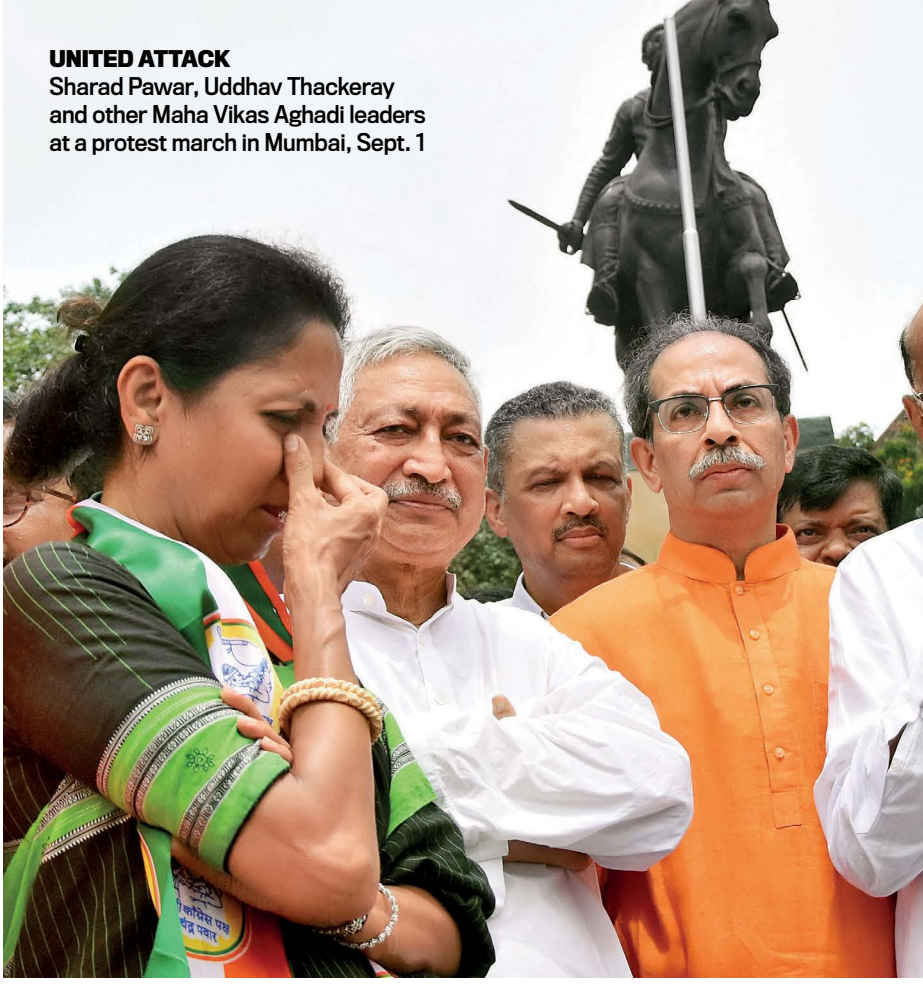
be given instructions to come up with a permanent solution.

Even so, the optics have been furthest from ideal for the Eknath Shinde regime, what with the Opposition is launching widespread protests. Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) leader and former minister Aaditya Thackeray attributed the collapse to poor quality of work and the "BJP's corruption". He alleged that the contractor who had erected the statue was close to the Shinde regime and the statue inauguration had been hastened keeping the Lok Sabha polls in mind. Nana Patole, president of the Maharashtra Pradesh Congress Committee (MPCC), charged that Apte was close to the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS). The Opposition duly demanded the scalp of the BJP's Ravindra Chavan, the PWD minister and guardian minister of Sindhudurg, the coastal district that hosts the fort.

Revered as the great Maratha king who took on the mighty Mughals in the 17th century, Shivaji's memory is sacrosanct in the state; Maharashtrians do not take kindly to any slight to his legacy. One only has to recall how Maratha outfit Sambhaji Brigade had ransacked the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute in Pune in 2004 over the perceived derogatory remarks by American author James Laine about the warrior-king and his mother Rajmata Jijabai in his book *Shivaji: A Hindu King in Islamic India*. In a campaign with barely-disguised anti-Brahmin undertones, the ruling Congress and Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) had then upped the ante against the opposition Shiv Sena and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), helping the Marathas and Bahujans consolidate behind the ruling allies. The NCP posted its best performance ever in the election that year, winning 71 out of the 288 seats in the assembly.

A similar script could well play out again, with the Mahayuti already on the back foot after a resurgent MVA walked away with 31 of Maharashtra's 48 seats in the Lok Sabha election this May. The statue controversy could undo the gains the government is hoping to make with



ANI

UNITED ATTACK
Sharad Pawar, Uddhav Thackeray and other Maha Vikas Aghadi leaders at a protest march in Mumbai, Sept. 1

"THE OPPOSITION IS ONLY SEEING POLITICS IN THE INCIDENT. THE PRIME MINISTER HAS OPENLY APOLOGISED TO ALL DEVOTEES OF SHIVAJI"
DEVENDRA FADNAVIS
Deputy Chief Minister, Maharashtra

"DID YOU NOTICE THE ARROGANCE IN [THE PRIME MINISTER'S] APOLOGY? IT REEKED OF ARROGANCE. ONE DEPUTY CHIEF MINISTER WAS SMILING"
UDDHAV THACKERAY
Former Maharashtra CM

CHRONICLE OF COLLAPSE

↘ **Dec. 4, 2023: Prime Minister Narendra Modi unveils a 35-foot-tall statue of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj at the Rajkot fort in Sindhudurg, a project commissioned by the Indian Navy. The state government spent Rs 2.40 crore on the statue and the pedestal**

↘ **Aug. 20: The state public works department, the agency responsible for the maintenance of the statue, writes to the Indian Navy, saying the nuts and bolts on the statue had rusted**

↘ **Aug. 26, 2024: The statue topples over**